

What should I believe?

If you think about it, our initial question really breaks down into two sub-questions.

When should I form a
new belief?

When should I discard
one of my beliefs?

Positive rules of belief will tell you
when you should form a certain
belief.

If you are in such-and-such
circumstances, you should
believe P.

Negative rules of belief will tell you
when you should not have a certain
belief.

If you are in such-and-such
circumstances, you should not
believe P.

It might at first seem extremely easy to formulate the rules of belief. The following would seem to be plausible candidates, respectively, for positive and negative rules of belief.

If P is true, you should
believe P .

If P is not true, you should
not believe P .

The problem with these rules of belief is not that they are incorrect; the problem is that in many cases they won't be of much practical use, since in many cases we don't know for sure whether the claim in question is true or false. (If we did, there would be no serious question about whether to form the belief.)

TRUTH → BELIEF

NO TRUTH → NO BELIEF

Let's start with what looks like a pretty good candidate to be a positive rule of belief. This rule says that, if you can give a good argument for something, you should believe it.

Well, what's a good argument?

Part of the answer is that a good argument should be valid.

But that's not demanding enough; there are plenty of valid arguments whose conclusions you should not believe. After all, some valid arguments have obviously false premises.

Good Argument $\rightarrow$ Belief

If there is a valid argument for P and you should believe each of that argument's premises, you should believe P.

These rules of belief seem plausible. But they don't answer every question we want answered.

Suppose that I am trying to put the first rule of belief into practice, and am trying to decide whether to believe the conclusion of some argument. To do this, I will have to decide whether I should believe the premises of the argument. But how do I do that?

The above rule of belief does not tell me.

Good Argument Against $\rightarrow$ No Belief

If there is a valid argument against P
and you should believe each of that
argument's premises, you should not
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